



COMPLAINTS POLICY - P-003

Policy Statement

Everyone has the right to expect a positive experience and a good treatment outcome. In the event of concern or complaint, patients have a right to be listened to and to be treated with respect. Service providers should manage complaints professionally so customers' concerns are dealt with appropriately. Good complaint handling matters because it is an important way of ensuring customers receive the service they are entitled to expect. Complaints are a valuable source of feedback; they provide an audit trail and can be an early warning of failures in service delivery. When handled well, complaints provide an opportunity to improve service and reputation.

Aims & Objectives

- We aim to provide a service that meets the needs of our patients and we strive for a high standard of care;
- We welcome suggestions from patients and from our clinicians and staff about the safety and quality of service, treatment and care we provide;
- We are committed to an effective and fair complaints system; and
- We support a culture of openness and willingness to learn from incidents, including complaints.

Promoting Feedback

Information is provided about the complaints policy and external complaints bodies that patients can go to with a complaint, such as Save Face Ltd in a variety of ways, including;

- On our website;
- Publicity about the service;
- Posters in reception;
- By clinicians and staff inviting feedback and comments.

If you have a concern or wish to make a complaint

Please advise us as soon as possible, an appointment will be made for you to be seen. It may be possible to discuss over the phone, or by email, if your concern is not related to a treatment outcome.

If your concern is related to a treatment outcome, we will need to see you in order to assess and document for the medical record.

Be assured

- We will Listen to your views on your experience and concerns
- We will document your views and concerns in the medical record and confirm with you that this record reflects your views and concerns accurately.
- We will treat you with respect, sensitivity and maintain confidentiality.

- All complaints are handled without prejudice or assumptions about how minor or serious.
- The emphasis will be on identifying the problem and how we might resolve the problem.
- We will establish what kind of resolution you expect.
- If possible your clinician will provide you with an explanation of what has happened, based on the known facts.
- If appropriate, your clinician will provide you with support, advice and/or propose a management plan depending on the assessment and diagnosis of the concern presented.
- We will provide you with a written summary of the assessment and discussion within (48) hours.
- You may request a copy of your medical record and report should you wish to seek a second opinion.

Clinicians and staff refer complaints to the Clinic Manager if:

- After attempting to resolve the complaint, they do not feel confident in dealing with the complainant; or
- The outcome you are seeking is beyond the scope of their responsibilities Or;
- They or you believe the matter should be brought to the attention of someone with more authority.
- You will be provided with the contact details of the manager referred to.

The complaints manager coordinates resolution of formal complaints in close liaison with the patient, treating clinician and other staff who are directly involved.

The Clinic Manager carries out investigations of complaints to identify what happened, the underlying causes of the complaint and preventative strategies.

Information is gathered from:

- Talking to clinicians and staff directly involved
- Factual written reports provided by staff involved in the incident
- Listening to the complainant's views on their experience and concerns
- Establishing what kind of resolution is expected
- Reviewing medical records and other records; and creating a coherent timeline of treatment episodes, reviews and communications.
- Gathering and reviewing any supporting documents and records
- Reviewing relevant policies, standards or guidelines.

At the conclusion of an inquiry or investigation, the complainant and relevant clinicians and staff are provided with all established facts, the causal factors contributing to the incident and any recommendations to improve the service, and the reasons for these decisions.

Records and Privacy

- The complaints manager maintains a complaints and patient feedback register (e.g. Save Face portfolio), with records of informal feedback (Suggestions for improvement and patient feedback forms) and formal complaints.
- All interactions with the complainant, including face to face, telephone, email or text are documented in the patient record.
- Personal information on individual complaints is kept confidential and is only made available to those who need it to deal with the complaint.

- Complainants are given notice about how their personal information is likely to be used during the investigation of a complaint.
- Individual complaints files are kept in a secure filing cabinet in the [complaints manager]'s office and in a restricted access section of the computer system's file server.
- Patients are provided with access to their medical records [in accordance with the confidentiality policy]. Others requesting access to a patients' medical records as part of resolving a complaint are provided with access only if the patient has provided authorisation [in accordance with the confidentiality policy].

Timeframes

- Formal complaints are acknowledged in writing or in person within 48 hours.
- The acknowledgment provides contact details for the person who is handling the complaint, how the complaint will be dealt with and how long it is expected to take.
- If a complaint raises issues that require notification or consultation with an external body, the notification or consultation will occur within three days of those issues being identified.
- Formal complaints are investigated and resolved within 14 days.
- If the complaint is not resolved within 20 days, the complainant, clinicians and staff who are directly involved in the complaint will be provided with an update.

The process of resolving the problem will include:

- An expression of regret to the patient for any harm or distress suffered;
- An explanation or information about what is known, without speculating or blaming others;
- Considering the problem and the outcome the patient is seeking and proposing a solution; and confirming that the patient is satisfied with the proposed solution.